the supply ministry and too little imports'.7 During this time, the situation looked so bleak that butter rationing became more stringent, salt and dried fish was substituted for meat and lard, and quark (skimmed milk cheese) took the place of butter. For many, memories of Hitler's wartime rationing came flooding back. 'It means wartime austerity again,' the West German press observed, predicting a clean-out in the GDR trade and supply ministries. (On cue, Dr Karl Hamann, Supply Minister, and his chief assistant, Rudolf Albrecht, were suspended from office).

The paradox of this drama was the Politburo's ill-judged decision to increase work quotas by 10 per cent across all state-owned factories, meaning workers had to produce more for the same wage. As if that wasn't bad enough, hikes in the price of sugar, milk, bread, healthcare and public transport caused outrage. At the notoriously threadbare HO government grocery stores, real coffee had not been sold for more than a year, while tea was a luxury few could afford, and eggs were scarce. Most cafes had nothing to sell – no soup, beer, or even sandwiches.

When added up, Ulbricht's Stalinisation amounted to a 33 per cent cut in the monthly wage, prompting a mass exodus of people to flee West. The sense of deflation in the SED worsened when a coal crisis emerged, prompting Ulbricht to appoint brigades of inquisitors to ferret out sabotage and failures in pit management. Ironically, at the same time, Grotewohl was still deceiving himself about responsibility by promising ruthless punishment of the 'men responsible' for the food shortages. Under an absurd new scheme, he set up fifteen commissions to make village-to-village tours, urging farmers to deliver more meat, wheat and other produce. Another directive called on farmers, officials and the public to 'leave desks and homes' and gather in the last of the crops. Labourers and tractor drivers on collective farms were called to 'mobilise all women and youths' and 'feel [themselves] responsible for every single sugar beet or potato'.8 The theme of every citizen doing their bit became a constant feature of SED propaganda during 1952.

Meanwhile, with the crisis deepening, the military sealed off the 600-mile East-West German border, leaving only crossings in Berlin accessible because it was administered by all four occupying powers. Thus, from this